

Instructor: Date:

Learner: Regional Branch:

Program: Center:

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Let's Start!

The magical life of Harry Houdini!



Learning Outcome

Describe social, urban and environmental change in written and spoken situations according to work and social contexts.

Can Do Statements

- I can talk about fame and work.
- I can talk about social or urban change.
- I can talk about what was done.

Ask your partner:

- What's the greatest magic trick you've ever seen?
- If you had to, do you think you could escape from a prison?

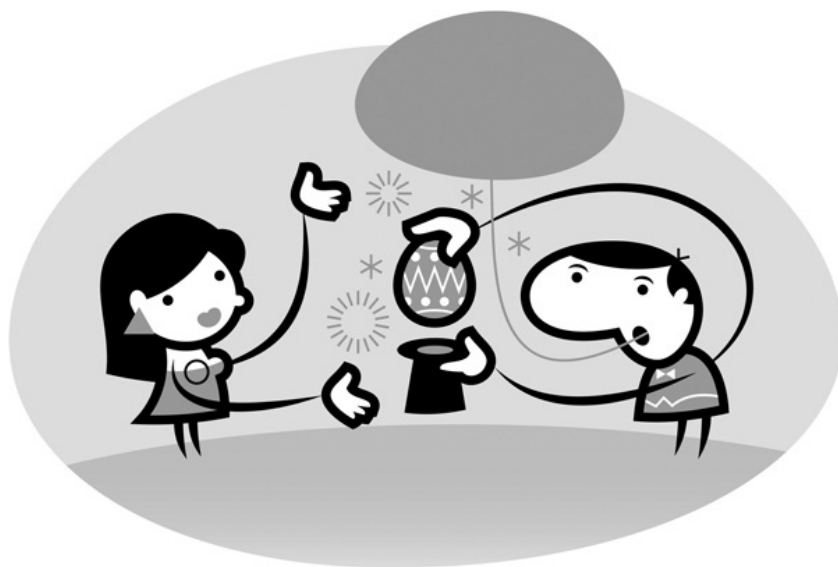




Let's Explore!

Houdini and **the great escape***!

* "The Great Escape" was also the title of a famous film starring Steve McQueen.



Instructions: Read the text aloud.

In 1894, an acclaimed magician, Harry Houdini, met the love of his life, Wilhelmina Rahner (Bess for short), on Coney Island. After a brief courtship, they were married, and Houdini's assistant, Theo, was soon replaced by Bess in the magic act. For decades to come, she shared the spotlight with her husband.

Early in his career, Houdini would bet his audience that he could escape any handcuffs they put on him. Eventually, he moved on to restraints such as coffins, straitjackets, and prison cells. He did all types of magic, but his grand escapes always stole the show. In 1899, a press agent discovered Houdini and he was soon booked into the biggest theaters in the country. The hype surrounding the famous escapist continued to grow, and his daring acts were always front-page news.

Houdini's career was not limited to the stage. In fact, he was a jack-of-all-trades. In 1916, he ventured into the world of movies, and his visionary nature also found expression in his many writings.

One evening as Houdini was resting, a young man came into the theater dressing room. Houdini's ability to endure stomach punches was well known, and the visitor wanted to put it to the test. Without warning, Houdini was smacked in the gut. A week and a half later, on October 31, 1926, Houdini died from an infection in the lining of his stomach. The greatest escape artist of all times could not escape his death.





Let's Practice!

A Renaissance man.

Instructions: Read the sentences aloud. Check your pronunciation with your instructor.

1. The hype surrounding the famous escapist continued to grow.
2. His daring acts were always front-page news.
3. Houdini's career was not limited to the stage. In fact, he was a jack of all trades.
4. In 1916, he ventured into the world of movies.
5. His visionary nature also found expression in his many writings.



Let's Practice!

Sharing the spotlight with Houdini.

Instructions: Use the words from the box to correctly complete the sentence.

Word Bank

visionary / acclaimed / front-page news / shared the spotlight / hype

1. In 1984, _____ magician Harry Houdini met the love of his life.
2. For decades to come, she _____ with her husband.
3. The _____ surrounding the famous escapist continued to grow.
4. His daring acts were always _____.
5. His _____ nature also found expression in his many writings.





Extension Activity

Plan your escape!

Instructions: Complete the following steps. Fill in the Self-Assessment.

- Imagine that the door to the room that you are currently in is suddenly sealed shut.
- Brainstorm a list of ways that you could possibly escape the room.
- Make a quick sketch of the route you would take and the materials you would need.
- Write a step-by-step plan outlining your escape.
- Present your escape plan to your partner.
- Make suggestions to your partner using *might have*, *would have*, and *could have*.

Self-Assessment

Yes No

I brainstorm an outline of how to get out of a locked room.

☐ ☐

I write a step-by-step plan.

☐ ☐

I share my plan with a partner.

☐ ☐

I speculate on what could have been done differently.

☐ ☐


Target Words

- **acclaimed** (adjective): praised by the public; respected
e.g. In 1894, acclaimed magician Harry Houdini met the love of his life.
- **share the spotlight** (expression): to divide public attention between more than one person
e.g. For decades to come, she shared the spotlight with her husband.
- **to steal the show** (expression): to attract the majority of the attention or praise
e.g. His grand escapes always stole the show.
- **hype** (noun): intensive publicity or promotion
e.g. The hype surrounding the famous escapist continued to grow.
- **front-page news** (expression): very important or noteworthy information
e.g. His daring acts were always front-page news.
- **visionary** (noun): someone who can predict the future with great accuracy
e.g. His visionary nature also found expression in his many writings.
- **press agent** (noun): a person who organizes promotions and publicity on behalf of a company or celebrity
e.g. In 1899, a press agent discovered Houdini.
- **jack of all trades** (expression): a person who can do many different things
e.g. He was a jack of all trades who dabbled in movies and writing.





Learning Points

The Simple Past Passive

You use an **active** structure when you want the 'doer' of the action to be the subject.
You use a **passive** structure when you want the 'receiver' of the action to be the subject.

You often choose the passive form when you want to talk about an action but are not so interested in saying who or what does/did it. Passives without *agents* (the doers) are common in biographies.

Active sentence = A fan (subject) **smacked** Houdini (object) in the gut.

Passive sentence = Houdini (subject) **was smacked** in the gut by a fan (agent).

It is not necessary to mention the object in a passive sentence.

You make the passive form of a verb by using tenses of the verb **to be** followed by the past participle.

subject	was/were	past participle	
Houdini	was	booked	into the biggest theaters in the country.
They	were	married	in 1894.

Examples:

- *After a brief courtship, they were married, and Houdini's assistant, Theo, was soon replaced by Bess in the magic act.*
- *In 1899, a press agent discovered Houdini and he was soon booked into the biggest theaters in the country.*
- *Houdini's ability to endure stomach punches was well known, and the visitor wanted to put it to the test.*
- *Without warning, Houdini was smacked in the gut.*

